THE NEW SUNDAY EXPRESS | SUNDAY STORY

ALMANAC TODAY
• Sunday 11/12/16 • Year: Durmukhi • Ritu: Himantha • Masa: Margashira
• Paksha: Shukla • Tithi: Dwadashi 01:05 pm • Nakshatra (Star): Bharani 01:33 am
• Moon in Mesha Rasi. • Today is Pradhosha, UNICEF Day • Rahukaala: 04:30 pm to 06:00 pm • Gulikakala: 03:00 am to 04:30 pm • Yamaganda: 12:00 pm to 01:30 pm

WEATHER WATCH
MIN 11°C | MAX 28°C
FORECAST
sunny.

Sunrise 6.32 am
Sunset 5.54 pm
Moonrise 3.37 pm
Moonset 3.27 am

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For 30 years now, Jnana Sanjeevini Medical Centre in Bengaluru is the go-to place for poor diabetics who can't afford the rich man's disease

Here, everyone from doctor to peon, can diagnose diabetes

SURAKSHA P @ Bengaluru

FIVE-YEAR-OLD Diganth R, unlike other children of his age, is not scared of needles. He is insulin-dependent. At Jnana Sanjeevini Medical Centre in JP Nagar, he sits obediently with his 25-year-old mother Shilpa N on a Saturday afternoon for his routine checkup. He has to be administered insulin four times a day, and Shilpa and her husband, who reside on KR Road, cannot afford two bottles of insulin every day.

They have a small pani puri shop to sustain their family of four. For thirty years now, Jnana Sanjeevini Medical Centre of the Samatvam Trust has been a go-to place for poor diabetics who can't afford the rich man's disease. The centre provides free insulin to children and medicines to adults. It has provided scholarships to children from school to college, around 40 of them. The centre is run by Dr S Srikanta who is a researcher in the field of endocrinology. He has been faculty at the Harvard Medical School and clinical investigator of National Institute of Health, USA.

A month of diabetes medication requires at least ₹4,000, provided there are no complications. Diabetics are prone to heart, kidney and eye problems. Those with severe diabetic foot also have to undergo amputations. To prevent this, Srikanta has trained around 18 community health workers who go around Ramanagara district to diagnose diabetes and either ask them to go to a primary health centre or visit Jnana Sanjeevini.

Dr Srikanta has touched the lives of one lakh families in the past three decades. The rural project is called Madhura Sanjeevini. These 18 barefoot doctors aren't even educated let alone have rudimentary medical education. But they do know that blood glucose levels between 100 and 125 when fasting is bordering diabetes and needs changes in lifestyle or medical intervention.

They are armed with a kit with essentials to diagnose diabetes — sugar meter, weighing scale, and a mobile with a software loaded on it. "When it indicates green, they know that the blood glucose is normal. When it shows yellow, they understand that the levels are worrisome and advise people on exercise or changes in diet, etc. When it reflects red they know that the levels are more than 125 on fasting blood and that they need to see a doctor," says Dr Srikanta.



Dr S Srikanta (left) with health workers during a diabetes screening programme at the clinic in J P Nagar | S MANJUNATH

Everyone reports to Rathnamma Srinivas. They maintain a register of their attendance and the houses they've covered. One thing that binds all of them is that someone in their family is a diabetic and has suffered the implications of it. So far they have screened at least 2,900 citizens.

"One-third of the patients who come to our centre pay, another one-third get subsidised treatment and one-third don't pay," says Dr Srikanta. Building the four-storeyed charity structure wasn't easy. Their benefactors include the GC Surana family of Micro Labs, Sarojini Damodaran Foundation, Infosys Foundation, Biocon Foundation, Sahayata Trust and other institutional and individual donors.

Srikanta's dream, however, is to take healthcare to the doorstep of the urban poor and rural poor. "Everyone should learn how to diagnose diabetes, from the office clerk to a doctor," he says.



3 DS TO TACKLE DIABETES

Community programmes run by Samatvam Trust

DISHA's beneficiaries include type 1 diabetics, children and youth, who are insulin dependent. One can 'adopt a child' financially and provide expenses, medical or otherwise. Samatvam also provides patient-parent support groups and residential health recreation camps

DOSTI's beneficiaries include type-II non-insulin dependent diabetic adults. They are given free checkups, free medicines, counselling services, psychosocial support

DEEPA caters to physicians and health counsellors. "We provide internships and fellowships. We have collaborated with NIMHANS in the past. Diabetes and mental health are closely related. We have also collaborated with IISc to develop devices for patients. We have also had foreign students," Dr Srikanta says.

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